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Self, Culture, and Society I | Section 17

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Sympathy and Self-Interest's Coexistence

In Adam Smith's *Theory of Moral Sentiments*, Smith explains morality through humans' natural tendency to socialize. Smith claims that much of man's moral judgements come from their capacity to sympathize with others, a trait that allows man to self-regulate their passion for self-interest. One could argue that sympathy is merely a feeling that is the product of self-interest—we feel for others in a social context because to not would tarnish our reputation or seem inhumane and it is in our best interest, socially, to sympathize with others. Smith successfully demonstrates that sympathy is not reducible to self-interest and that sympathy is a driver of social interaction innate to humans.

Smith begins to prove that sympathy is innate rather than a product of self-interest by explaining that man gains nothing social or material from expressing it. Smith opens his first section with, "How selfish soever man may be supposed, there are evidently some principles in his nature, which interest him in the fortune of others, and render their happiness necessary to him, though he derives nothing from it except the pleasure of seeing it" (Smith, *TMS* 11). Smith acknowledges that man is disposed toward acting through selfish motives but goes on to say that man also derives emotional wellbeing, pleasure, through the wellbeing of others. While another person's happiness doesn't always have a tangible positive effect on or contribute to material gain of an observer, it is in man's social nature that the wellbeing of another contributes to the

wellbeing of himself. Smith further explains this point by explaining that we have a disposition to express sympathy even when no one is the recipient of pleasure:

> "In such cases, that there may be some correspondence of sentiments between the spectator and the person principally concerned, the spectator must, first of all, endeavour, as much as he can, to put himself in the situation of the other, and to bring home to himself every little circumstance of distress which can possibly occur to the sufferer" (Smith, *TMS* 26).

Smith observes that when a spectator is met with a sufferer of some wrong, such as violence, he attempts to fully understand the negative emotions that the sufferer could be experiencing. Unlike the sympathetic attitude which allows the spectator's emotional wellbeing to be improved by another man's wellbeing, here there is no improvement to the wellbeing of the spectator. It seems almost counterintuitive for the spectator to sympathize with someone whose situation could bring them distress since distress is not an emotion man necessarily seeks to feel—if anything, by attempting to internalize the feelings of a sufferer, the spectator is going against the natural self-interest man has to improve and care for himself.

While Smith has established that sympathy is not always a product of self-interest, he also explicates that sympathy can be a natural means to satisfy self interest; he cautions the reader that the form of self-interest that is being satisfied is not selfishness, but self-love. When speaking on the pleasure of mutual sympathy, Smith explains that when a spectator sympathizes with another man, the spectator is approving of their reaction to a situation, and therefore fulfilling man's desire for assistance; to man, the spectator's sympathy is approbation (Smith, *TMS* 17). Later on, Smith relates the principle of approbation to self love and tells the reader that approval from society is necessary to feel at ease in a community which compels him to make

this distinction: “Sympathy, however, cannot, in any sense, be regarded as a selfish principle. When I sympathize with your sorrow or your indignation, it may be pretended, indeed, that my emotion is founded in self-love, because it arises from bringing your case home to myself, from putting myself in your situation, and thence conceiving what I should feel in the like circumstances (Smith, *TMS* 374). By “bringing” someone else’s case to themself, the spectator’s sympathy is inclusive of the welfare of others in society and is satisfying, not only the natural human tendency to sympathize, but also the social need for approbation from others. Because of the social nature of sympathy in this case, Smith defines sympathy as a form of appealing to others’ self-love rather than being a selfish passion. An example of this appeal to self-love is represented in Part 1, Chapter 2: “When we have read a book or poem so often that we can no longer find any amusement in reading it by ourselves, we can still take pleasure in reading it to a companion…, and we are amused by sympathy with his amusement which thus enlivens our own” (Smith, *TMS* 17-18). Reading a book or poem that you no longer enjoy to a companion is an action of self-love because you are reading with the purpose of satisfying your need to feel pleasure you lost over time. This act is an appeal to others’ self love because reciprocation of amusement shows sympathy through approbation and the pleasure that the reading will bring the companion benefits the companions emotional wellbeing.

Appealing to your own and others’ self-love is, in turn, an efficacious act of sympathy that can drive social interaction. Smith brings back this point in *The Wealth of Nations*: “It is not from the benevolence of the butcher, the brewer, or the baker that we expect our dinner, but from their regard to their own interest. We address ourselves, not to their humanity, but to their self-love, and never talk to them of our own necessities, but of their advantages” (Smith, *Wealth* Book I, Chapter 2). Smith’s economic theory is largely based on self interest, and his callback to

appealing to self-love in the context of interaction with an economic system shows how successful self-love can be as a facilitator of social interaction.

Self-interest and sympathy, both crucial aspects of appealing to others and satisfying man's own self-love in the socially beneficial interaction just described, are therefore both basic passions of man that contribute to efficacious social interaction in Smith's eyes. Even while sympathy can serve self-interest, it is also a distinct passion, inherent to man's nature.

Works Cited

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